

New Zealand

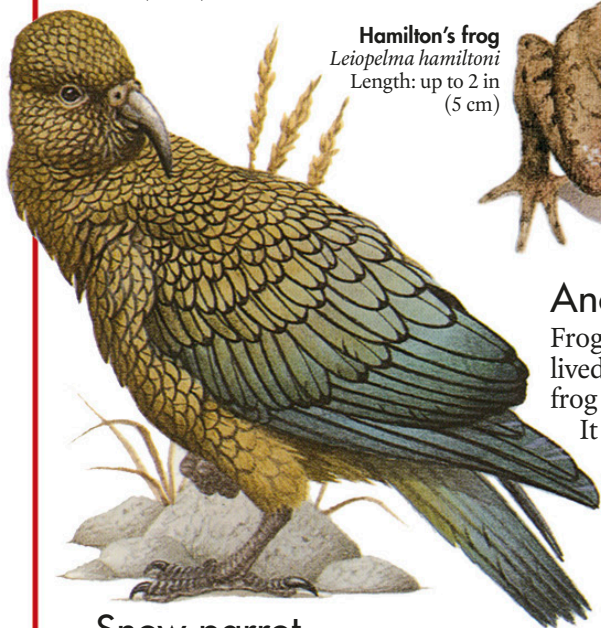


THE ISLANDS of New Zealand lie about 1,000 miles (1,600 km) east of Australia. New Zealand has a cool, wet climate in which forests and grasslands flourish. New Zealand split off from the other landmasses about 80 million years ago, before mammals became a major animal group. As a result, there are only two land mammals native to the country, both of them bats. Birds have been able to take advantage of the lack of mammals in New Zealand, and often live in habitats normally used by mammals elsewhere.

Crawling bat

The rare New Zealand short-tailed bat is good at moving around on the ground and can run fast on all fours, even up steep slopes.

Kea
(*Nestor notabilis*)
Length: up to 19 in (48 cm)



Hamilton's frog
(*Leiopelma hamiltoni*)
Length: up to 2 in (5 cm)



New Zealand lesser short-tailed bat
(*Mystacina tuberculata*)
Wingspan: up to 12 in (30 cm)



Ancient frog

Frogs like the rare Hamilton's frog lived 150 million years ago. This frog has no eardrums or vocal sac. It develops into a froglet while it is inside the egg.

Snow parrot

The kea is an unusual parrot that lives in the snowy Southern Alps. It uses its beak to dig up roots and shoots under the snow, but it also eats meat. It has been known to eat hikers' boots and to tear up campers' tents.



The Southern Alps contain many lakes, which were carved out by glaciers during the Ice Age.

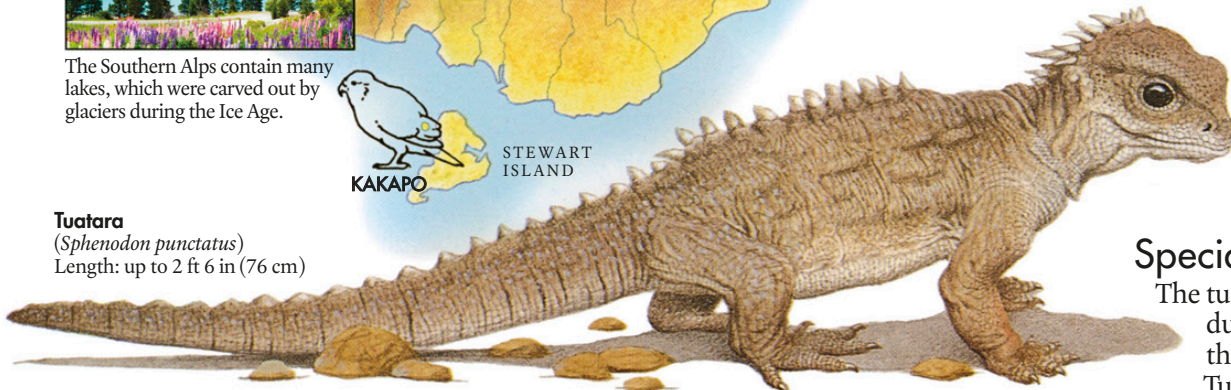


NEW ZEALAND
LESSER SHORT-TAILED BAT



KAKAPO

Tuatara
(*Sphenodon punctatus*)
Length: up to 2 ft 6 in (76 cm)



Special survivor

The tuatara is related to a group of reptiles that lived during the age of the dinosaurs. The male can raise the spines along his back to scare off other animals. Tuataras can live for 120 years.

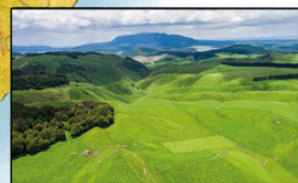
Northern brown kiwi
(*Apteryx mantelli*)
Height: up to 25.5 in (65 cm)
Bill: up to 1 ft (30 cm)



Furry feathers

The brown kiwi is a flightless bird. It is covered in long feathers that look like fur. The kiwi hunts at night for worms and insects. It finds its prey with its acute hearing and the nostrils on the tip of its sensitive bill.

KILOMETERS
0 50 100 150
MILES
0 25 50 75 100



Land on the slopes of the eastern hills on the North Island is used for grazing sheep and dairy cattle.

Flightless parrot

The kakapo, or owl parrot, is the world's only flightless parrot. It only uses its short wings to glide down from trees, and it can run very fast. It comes out at night to hunt for berries, roots, leaves, and lizards.



Kakapo
(*Strigops habroptila*)
Length: up to 2 ft 1 in (64 cm)



Evergreen trees and tree ferns are the most common plants in New Zealand's forests.